Peter J. Tobin College of Business: Interdisciplinary Business Retention

Office of Data Science and Analytics

2024-02-16

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Executive Summary

A plurality of first-time freshman entering the Tobin School of Business enroll as Interdisciplinary Business (or 'IDB', formerly known as Business) majors. Overall, Tobin freshman retain at higher rates than the university average. However, IDB freshman retain at significantly lower rates than students in all other Tobin majors, and even lower than the university average retention rate. After thorough analysis, we are unable to identify a variable that would potentially explain the observed retention trends of this group.

The following analysis is focused on the entering classes of Fall 2018 to Fall 2022. The Fall 2023 class has been excluded, as we will not have retention data on this cohort until Fall 2024.

Key Findings

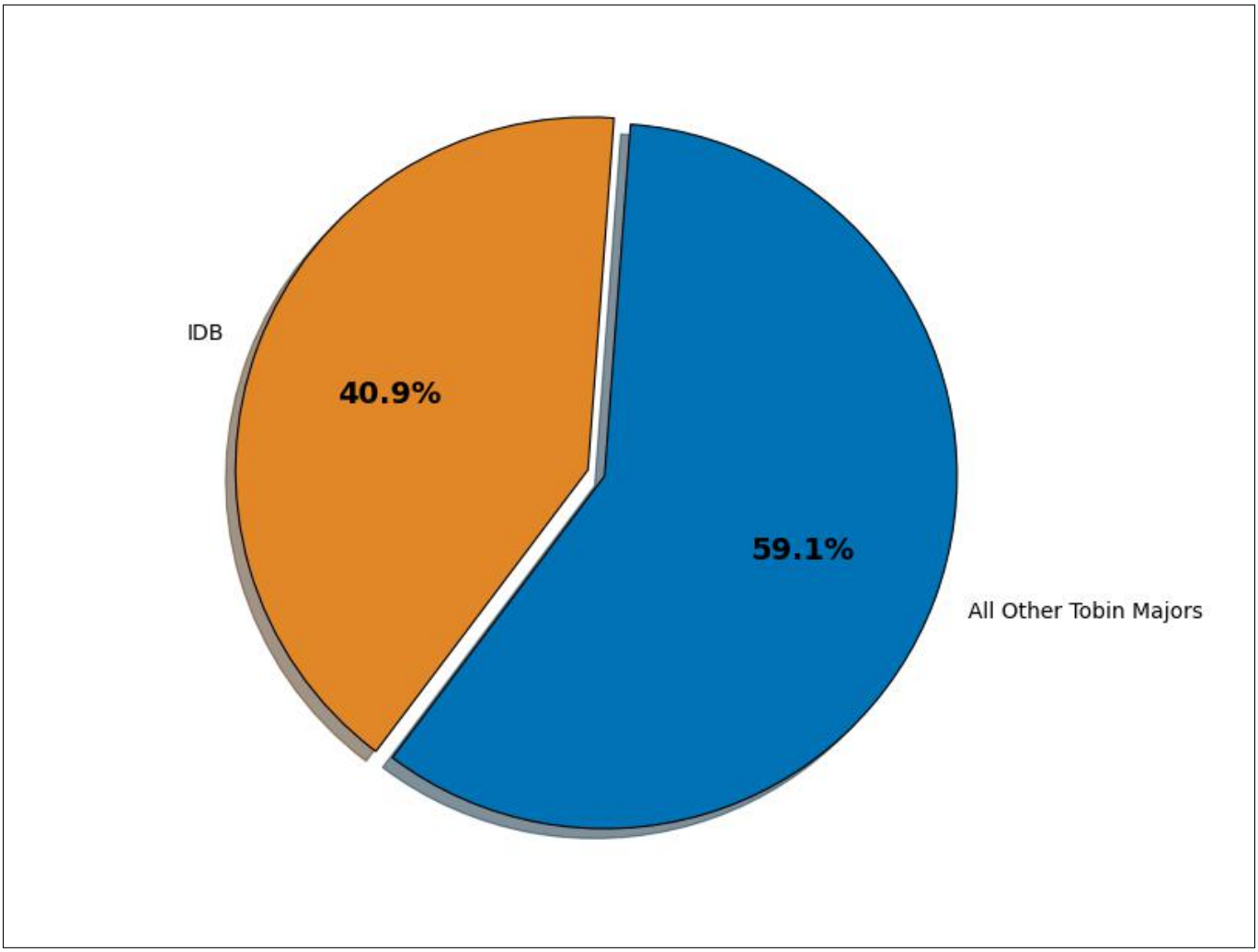
1. IDB majors account for roughly 40% of first-time freshman in Tobin from Fall 2018 to Fall 2022 (Fig. 1.1)
2. IDB majors consistently retain at lower rates than other Tobin majors, and have many years retained lower than the university average retention rate (Fig 1.2).
3. IDB majors are significantly more likely to have financial need, and have significantly lower high school GPAs than all other Tobin majors (Fig 2.2, 3.1). While both of these variables are known to correlate with lower retention rates, neither are sufficient in explaining the observed retention of IDB students (Fig 5.1).
4. Tobin Undecided majors retain at higher rates than IDB majors (Fig 3.3). While Undecided majors account for only about 20% of the enrollment compared to IDB students, it may be worth investigating the curriculum and management of the undecided students to that of the IDB students.
5. IDB majors are offered institutional scholarships in nearly identical proportions to all other Tobin majors when controlling for high school GPA (Fig 6.1)
6. When IDB majors leave St. John's in good standing, they do not turn down significantly higher scholarship offers than other Tobin majors.

1 Overview

First Year Student Distribution

Roughly 40% of first-time freshman entering the Tobin School of Business enroll as Interdisciplinary Business majors. The remaining 60% of freshman are divided among ten alternative majors in the college.

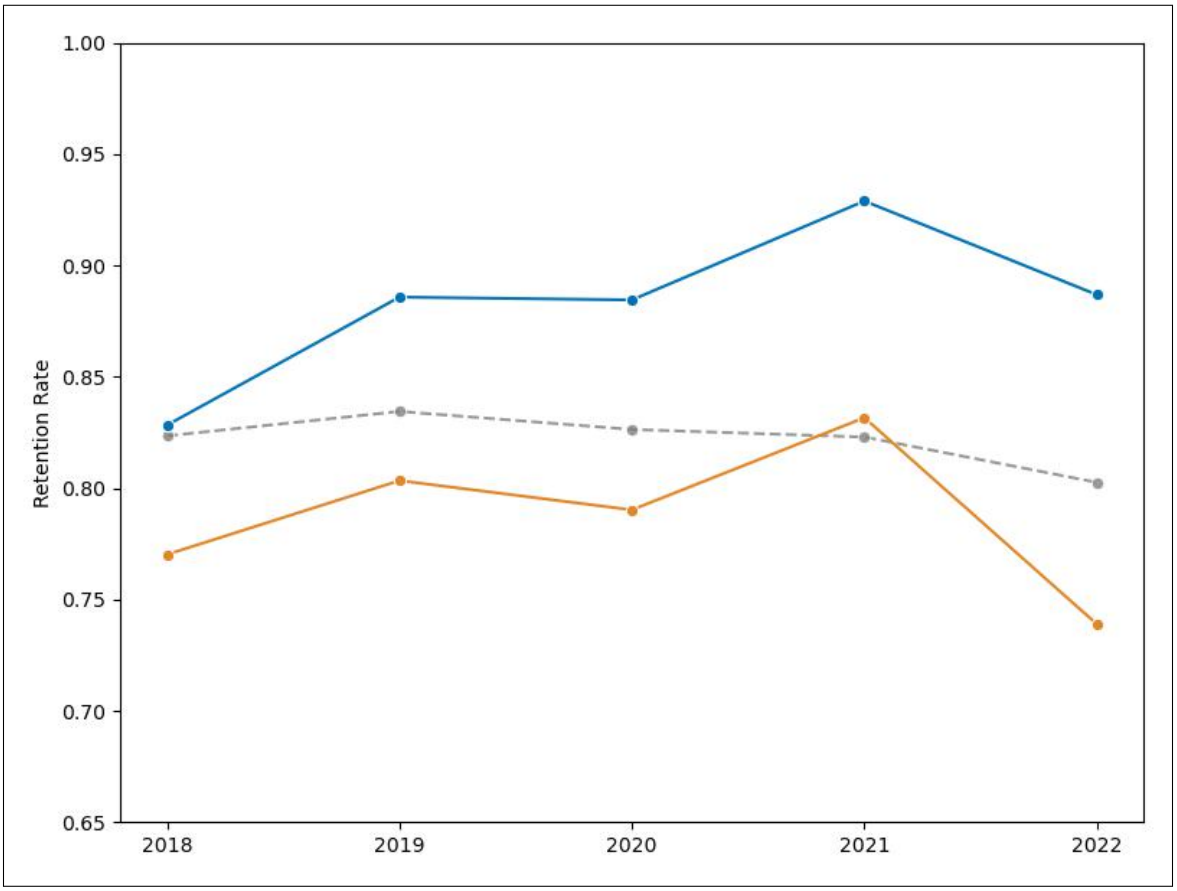
Figure 1.1: Entering Freshman
Fall 2018 - Fall 2022



Yearly Retention

Since the Fall of 2018, IDB students have retained at lower rates than all other Tobin majors, and most years have retained at below the university average retention rate

Figure 1.2: Fall-to-Fall Retention of IDB Majors, All Other Tobin Majors, and All St. John's Students

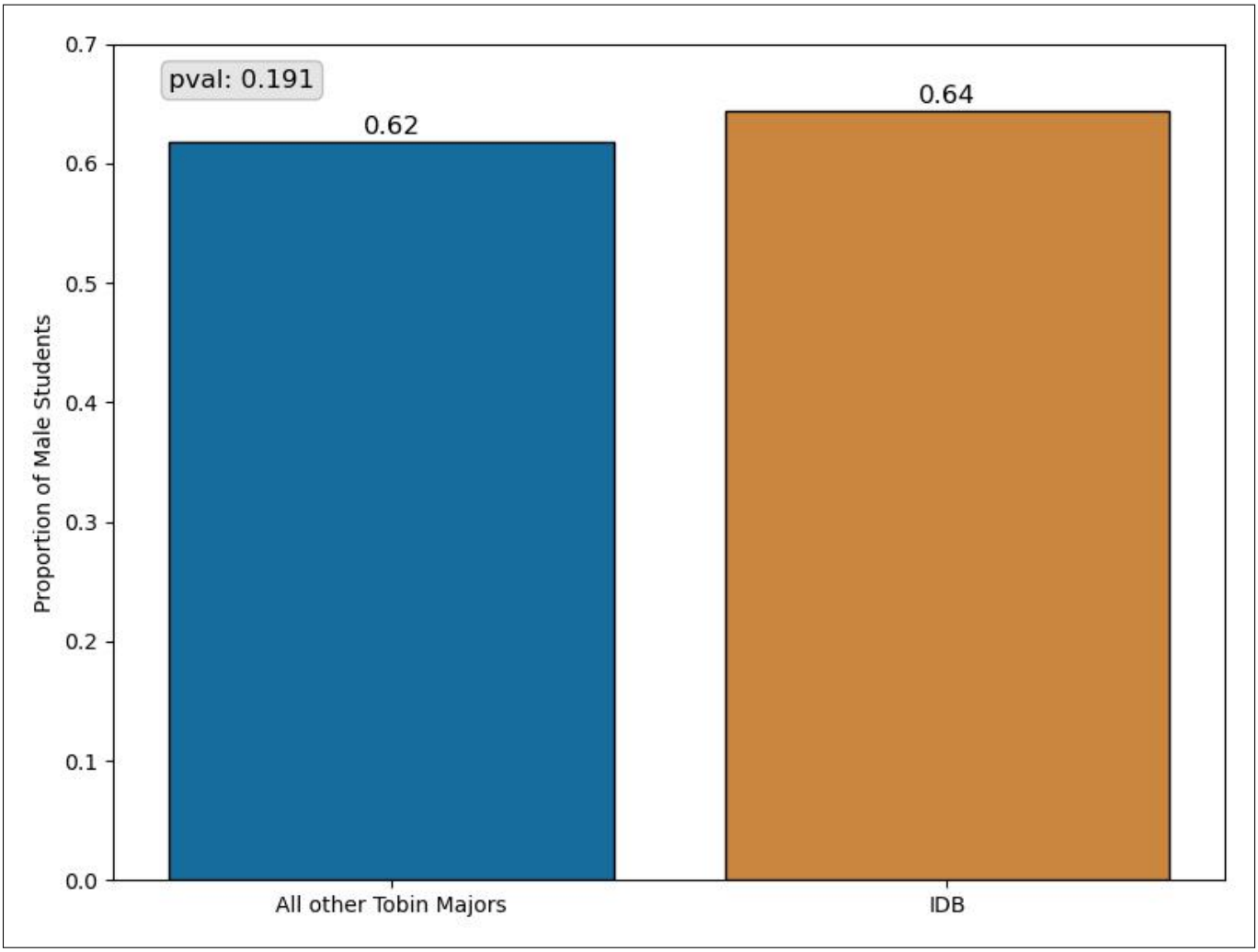


2 Demographics

Gender

IDB students tend to skew more male than other Tobin majors, though the difference is not statistically significant.

Figure 2.1: Gender Proportions

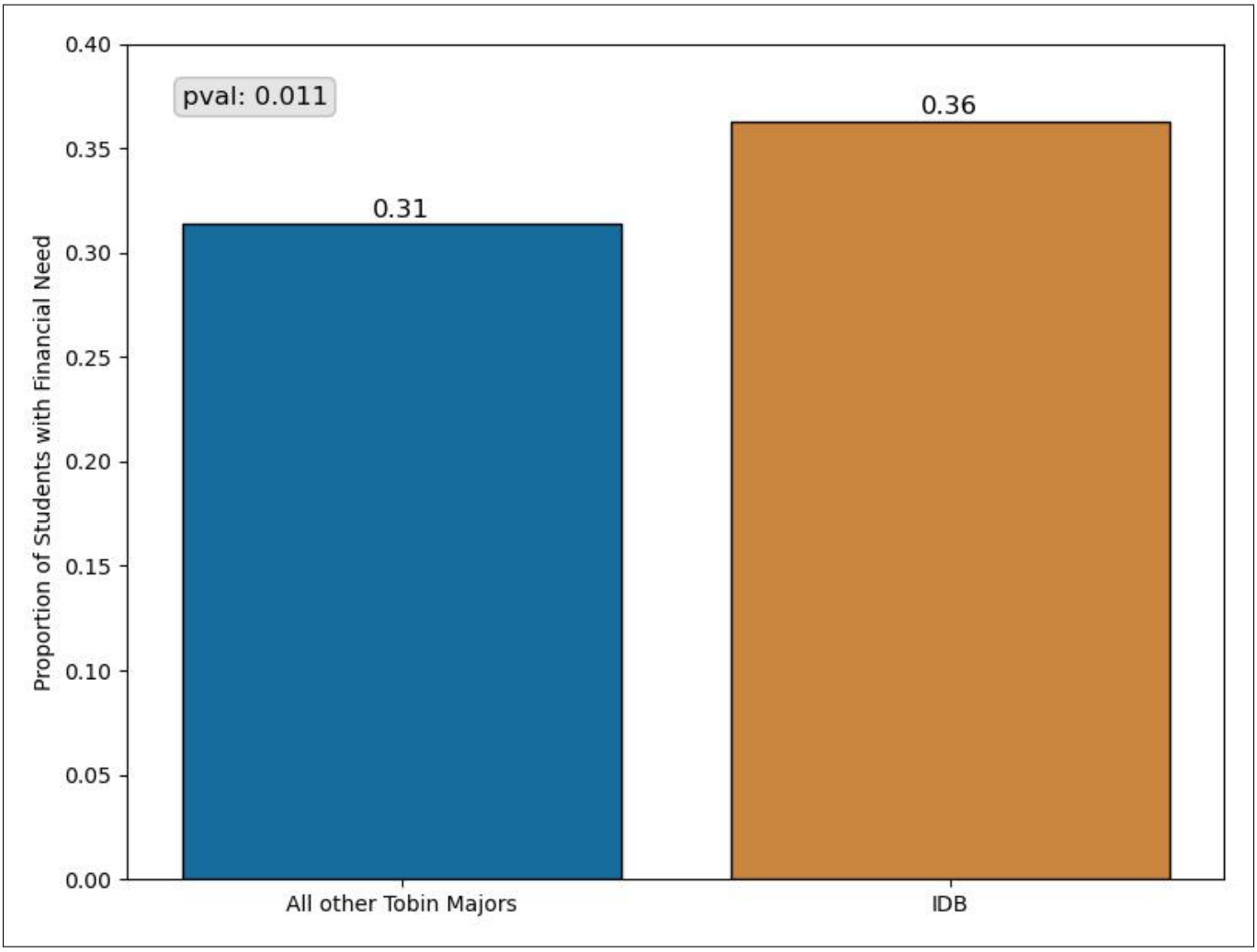


Financial Need

IDB students show significantly higher rates of financial need than students in other Tobin majors.

NOTE: Financial need is determined by the Office of Financial Aid

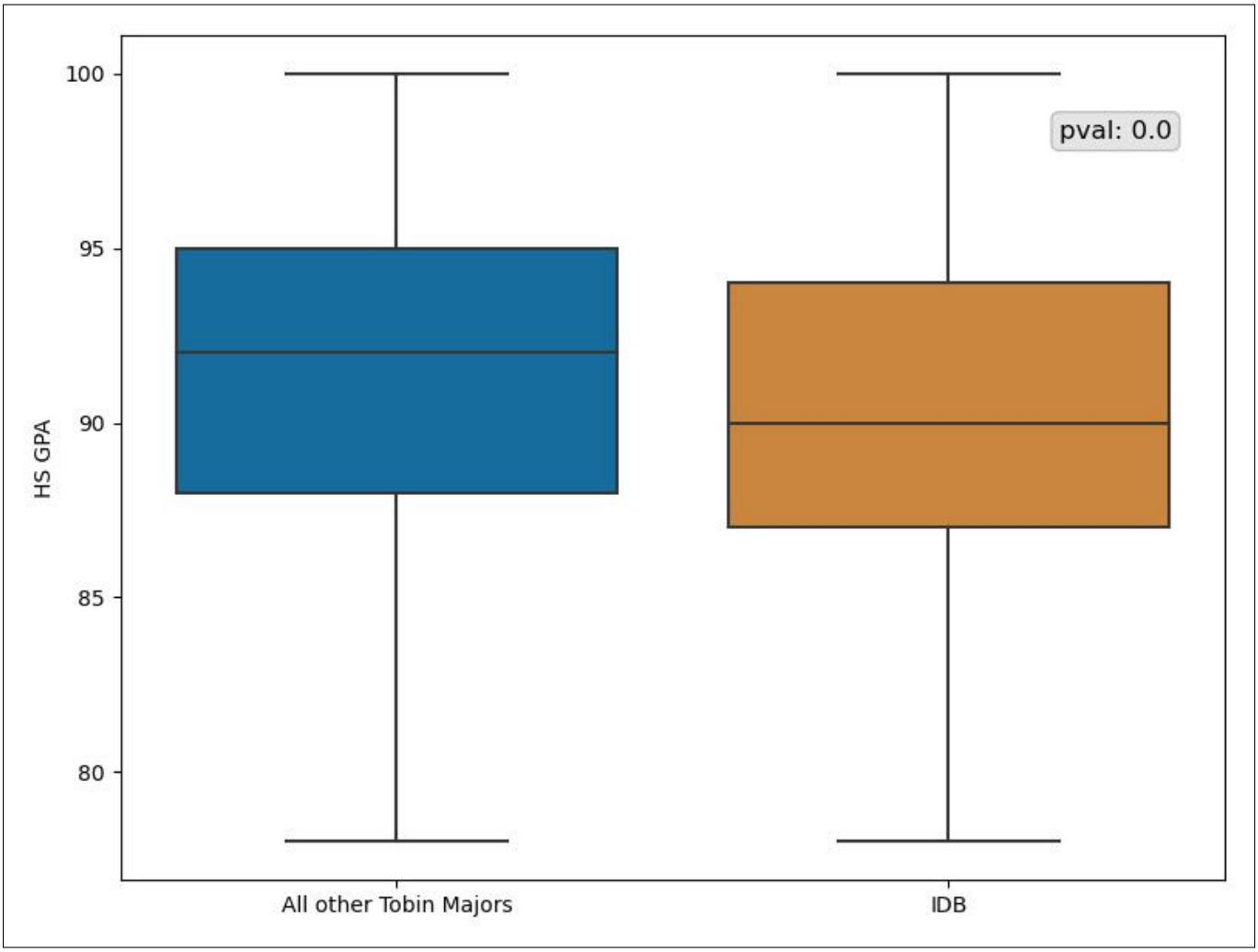
Figure 2.2: Financial Need Proportions



3 High School GPA

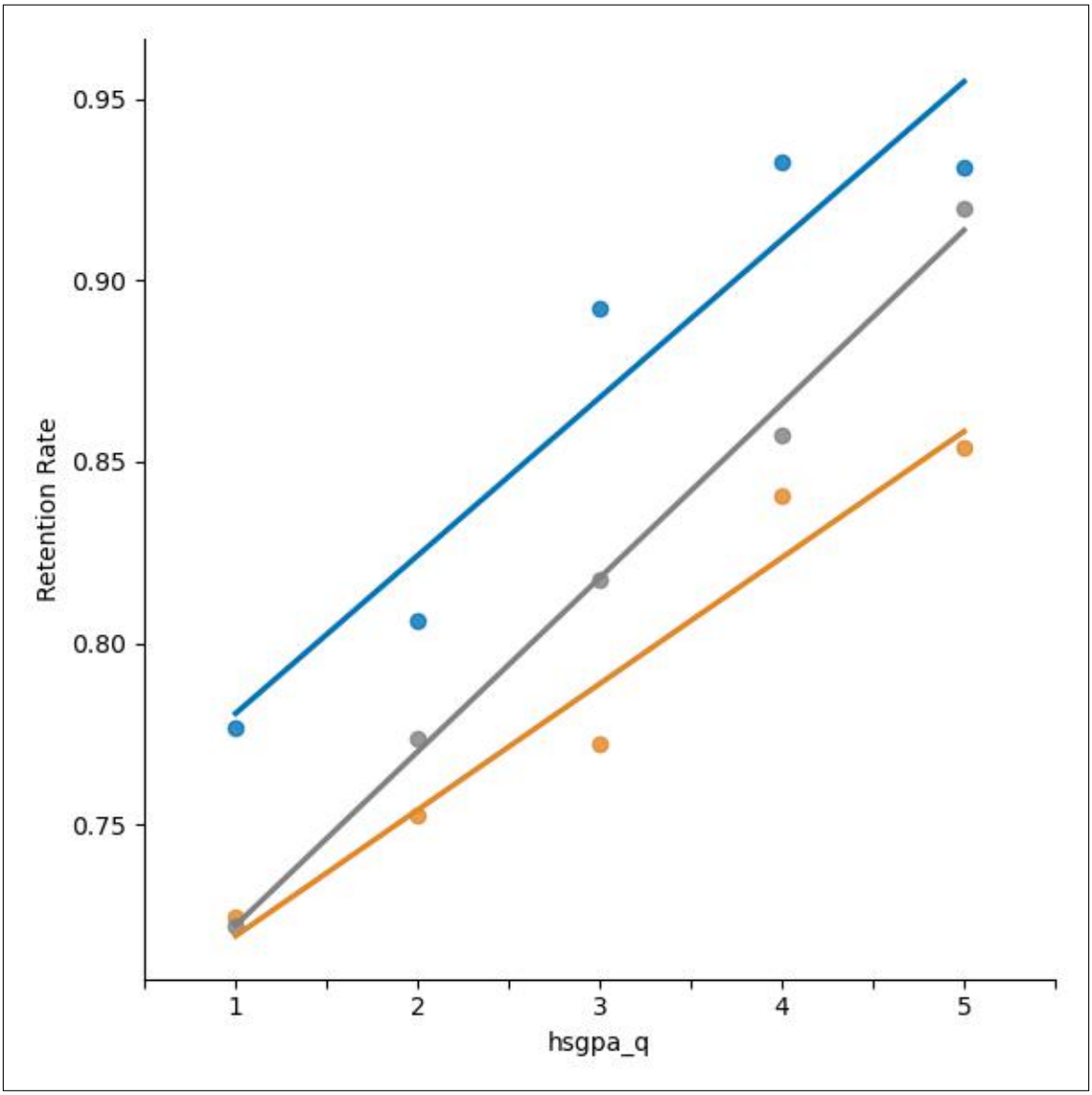
IDB students enter the college with significantly lower high school GPAs than all other Tobin majors.

Figure 3.1: Average High School GPA



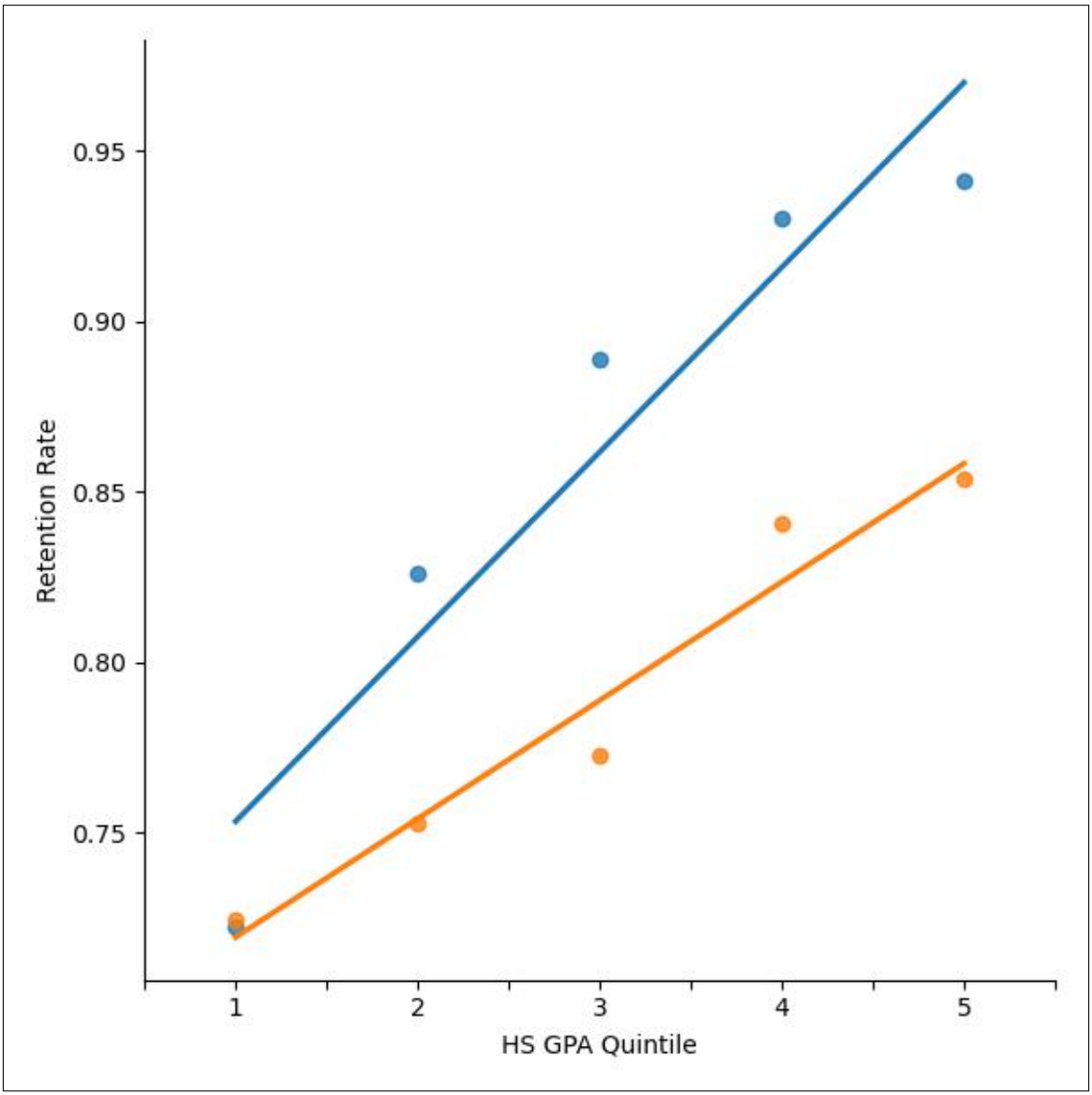
However, when controlling for this disparity in high school GPA, students in the IDB major still retain at lower rates than all other Tobin majors, and lower still than the institute-wide retention rate.

Figure 3.2: Retention by HS GPA Quintile of IDB Majors, All Other Tobin Majors, and All St. John's Students



Moreover, IDB majors retain at lower rates than Tobin Undecided majors when controlling for high school GPA.

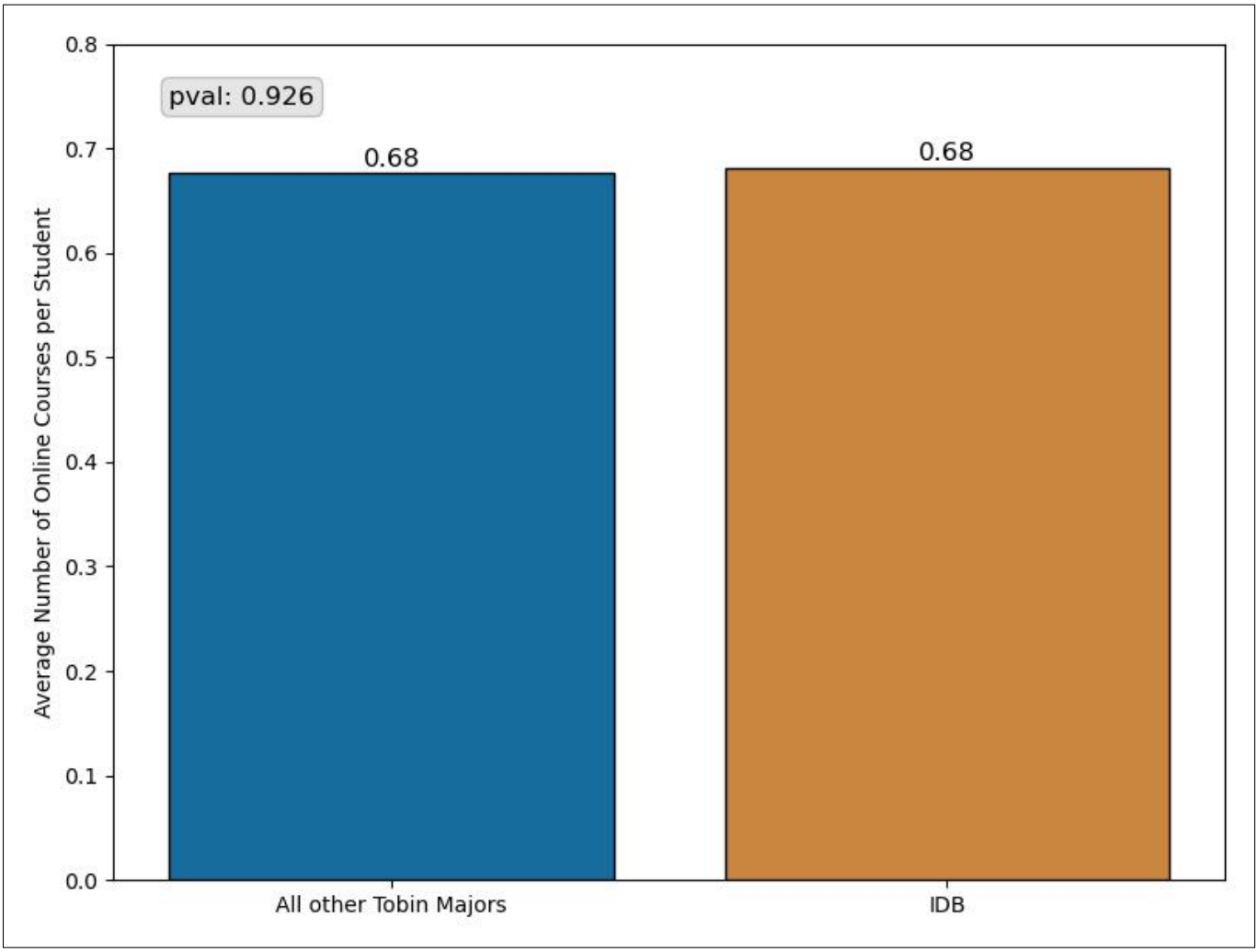
Figure 3.3: Retention by HS GPA Quintile of IDB Majors
Vs. Tobin Undecided Majors



4 Online Courses

IDB Students enroll in online courses at nearly identical rates as students in all other Tobin majors. This has been ruled out as an explanatory variable in the retention analysis.

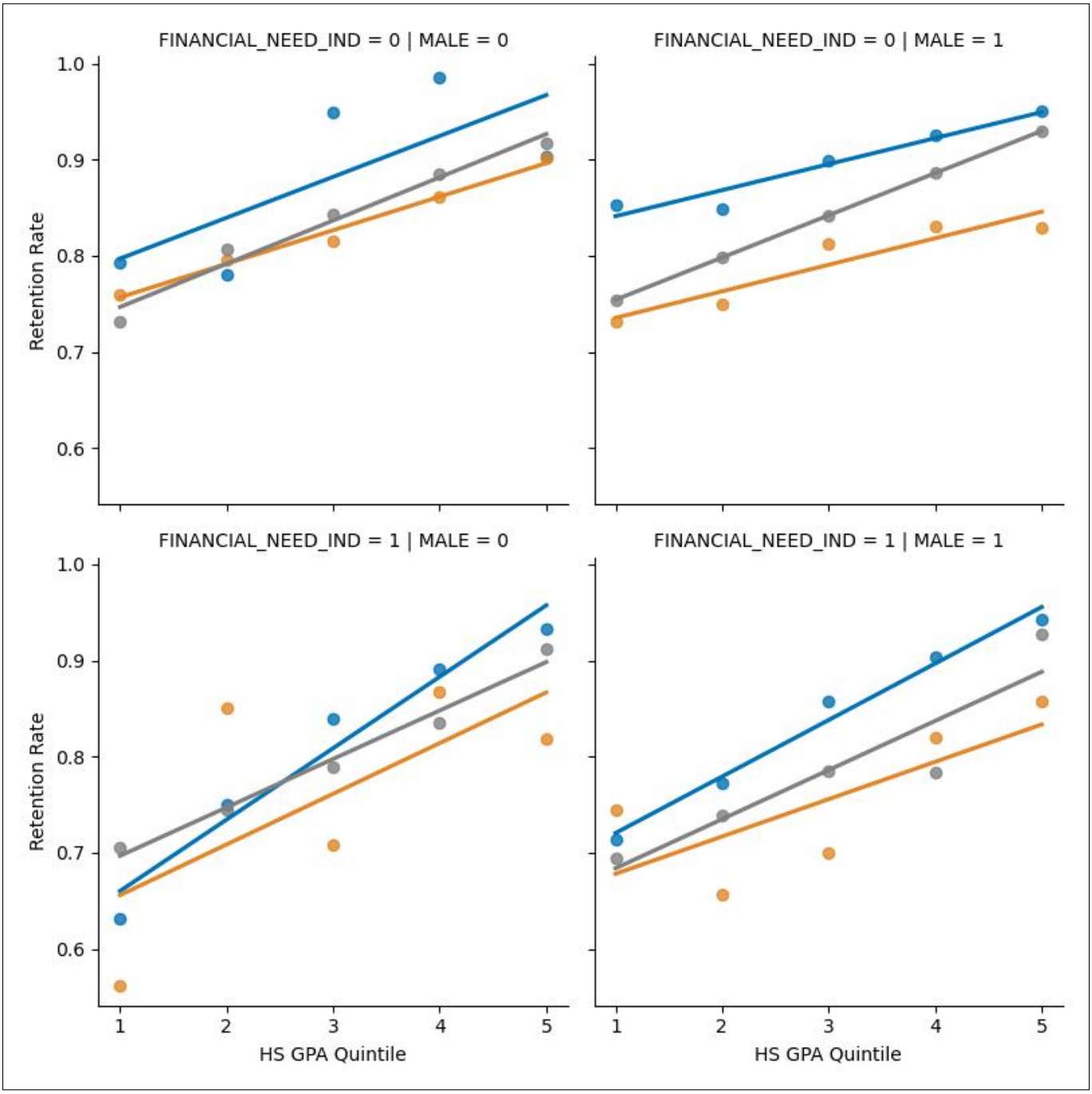
Figure 4.1: Average First Term Online Course Registrations



5 Controlled Comparison

High school GPA, gender, and financial need are known to correlate with retention rates. When controlling for these variables, IDB students still retain lower than all other Tobin majors, as well as the university average retention rate.

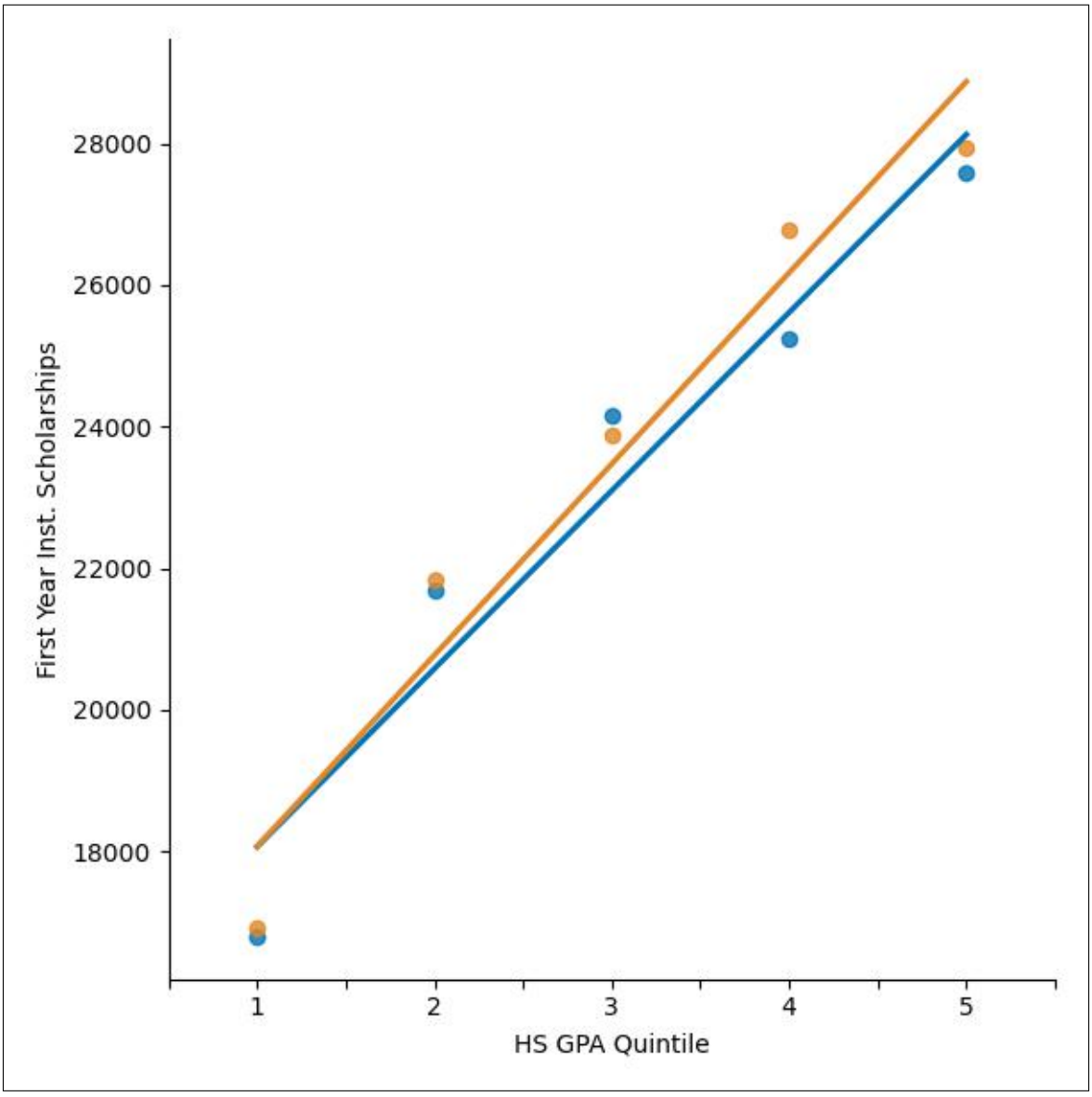
Figure 5.1: Retention by HS GPA Quintile, Financial Need, and Gender of IDB Majors, All Other Tobin Majors, and All St. John's Students



6 Scholarships

First-year institutional scholarship offers correlate positively with high school GPA. When controlling for high school GPA, IDB freshman are given nearly identical scholarship offers to all other Tobin freshman.

Figure 6.1: Institutional Scholarships by HS GPA Quintile of
IDB Majors and All Other Tobin Majors



When IDB freshman leave in good academic standing (average GPA >= 3.0), they do not leave significantly higher scholarship offers than students in other Tobin majors.

Figure 6.2: Scholarship Offers of Students Leaving in Good Standing

